



LOS ANGELES-RAISED Hector Alessandro Negrete waits to board his flight from Tijuana to Guadalajara.

COLUMN ONE

Migrant retakes life's reins in Mexico

Brought to the U.S. as a baby, the L.A. man without papers trades worry and fear for agency and hope.

By ANDREA CASTILLO

On an overcast morning in September, Hector Alessandro Negrete left his beloved Los Angeles — the city he was brought to at 3 months old — and headed down Interstate 5 to Mexico, the only country where he held a passport.

It was a place that, to him, had “always felt like both a wound and a possibility.”

Negrete, 43, sat in the passenger seat as a friend steered the car south and two more friends in another car followed. He had condensed his life to three full suitcases and his dachshund mix, Lorca.

They pulled over at the beach in San Clemente. Angel Martinez, his soon-to-be former roommate, is deeply spiritual, and his favorite prayer spot is the ocean, so he prayed that Negrete would be blessed and protected — and Lorca too — as they began a new stage in their lives.

On the near-empty beach, the friends embraced and wiped away tears. Martinez handed Negrete a small watermelon.

As instructed, Negrete walked to the edge of the water, said his own prayer and, as a gift of thanks to the cosmos, plopped it into a crashing wave.

Negrete doesn't call it self-deportation.

[See Migrant, A6]

An earlier call for Altadena evacuations went unheeded

Official says county fire department responsible for ‘gap’ when alerts were needed and actually ordered

By GRACE TOOHEY AND TERRY CASTLEMAN

The Eaton fire was cutting a destructive path into Altadena and parts of northern Pasadena just before Jan. 8 when some fire officials urged more widespread evacuations.

With home after home going up in flames, several Los Angeles County firefighters on the ground suggested to incident commanders that the rest of the nearby foothill communities, from Altadena west into La Cañada Flintridge, be evacuated.

Most of east Altadena had been evacuated, but residents on the west side had not yet been told to flee. They were not even under an evacuation warning.

For unknown reasons, it took another three hours — and in some cases even longer — for officials to issue west Altadena mandatory evacuation orders.

By then, homes in the area were on fire and residents were in danger, as embers rained down on streets and smoke filled bedrooms and obscured sight lines. In the end, all but one of the 19 people who died in the Eaton fire were found in this section of Altadena.

The evacuation recommendation, re-

vealed in county documents released last month, raises new questions about the L.A. County Fire Department's handling of the Eaton fire.

County Supervisor Kathryn Barger, who represents Altadena, conceded last week that the county fire department was responsible for what she called “a gap” between when evacuation alerts were needed and actually ordered.

“That was where the breakdown was,” Barger told The Times. “There was a gap there.”

West Altadena received its first evacuation order at 3:25 a.m., four hours after 911 callers started reporting smoke and flames in the area. Some parts of west Altadena weren't evacuated until just before 6 a.m.

The Times first reported in January the disparity between when the fire threatened west Altadena and when residents were ordered to leave.

Barger pointed specifically to the period from 1:12 a.m. to 3 a.m., when the Office of Emergency Management received no direction to send out evacuation alerts,

[See Fires, A12]



GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

FOR ALL THE MARBLES

Shohei Ohtani singles in the first inning. For Dodgers-Blue Jays game reports, analysis, photos and videos from Game 7 in Toronto on Saturday, go to latimes.com or latimes.com/enewspaper.



AI robots’ ‘physical’ education

The race is on to teach humanoids how to move like people in the real world — even folding towels

By NILESH CHRISTOPHER

CHENNAI, India — Now that artificial intelligence has mastered almost everything we do online, it needs help learning how we physically move around in the real world.

A growing global army of trainers is helping it escape our computers and enter our living rooms, offices and factories by teaching it how we move.

In an industrial town in southern India, Naveen Kumar, 28, stands at his desk and starts his job for the day: folding hand towels hundreds of times, as precisely as possible.

He doesn't work at a hotel; he works for a startup that creates physical data used to train AI.

He mounts a GoPro camera to his forehead and follows a regimented list of hand movements to capture exact point-of-view

footage of how a human folds.

That day, he had to pick up each towel from a basket on the right side of his desk, using only his right hand, shake the towel straight using both hands, then fold it neatly three times. Then he had to put each folded towel in the left corner of the desk.

If it takes more than a minute or he misses any steps, he has to start over.

His firm, a data labeling company called Objectways, sent 200 towel-folding videos to its client in the United States. The company has more than 2,000 employees; about half of them label sensor data from autonomous cars and robotics, and the rest work on generative AI.

Most of them are engineers, and few are

[See Technology, A18]

Prop. 50 win may not change House control

With partisan redistricting battles erupting across U.S., either major party could see a net gain in seats

By ANA CEBALLOS AND SEEMA MEHTA

WASHINGTON — The hurried push to revise California's congressional districts has drawn national attention, large sums of money, and renewed hope among Democrats that the effort may help counter a wave of Republican redistricting initiatives instigated by President Trump.

But if Democrats succeed in California, the question remains: Will it be enough to shift the balance of power in Congress?

To regain control of the House, Democrats need to flip three GOP seats in the midterm elections next year. That slim margin prompted the White House to push Republicans this summer to redraw maps in GOP states in an effort to keep Democrats in the minority.

Texas was the first to signal it would follow Trump's edict and set off a rare mid-decade redistricting arms race that quickly roped in California, where Gov. Gavin Newsom devised Proposition 50 to tap into his state's massive inventory of congressional seats.

Californians appear poised to approve the

measure Tuesday. If they do, Democrats potentially could gain five seats in the House — an outcome that mainly would offset the Republican effort in Texas that already passed.

While Democrats and Republicans in other states also have moved to redraw their maps, it is too soon to say which party will see a net gain, or predict voter sentiment a year from now, when a lopsided election in either direction could render the remapping irrelevant.

GOP leaders in North Carolina and Missouri approved new maps that likely will yield one new GOP seat in each, Ohio Republicans could pick up two more seats in a newly redrawn map approved Friday, and GOP leaders in Indiana, Louisiana, Kansas and Florida are considering or taking steps to redraw their maps. In all, those moves could lead to at least 10 new Republican seats, according to experts tracking the redistricting efforts.

To counter that, Democrats in Virginia passed a constitutional amendment that, if approved by voters, would give lawmakers the power and option to redraw a new map ahead of next

[See Prop. 50, A12]

Warner chief seeks big role as sale looms

Zaslav eager to prove critics wrong and seal turnaround after three years of cuts, setbacks.

By MEG JAMES

Paramount Chairman David Ellison's latest offer to buy Warner Bros. Discovery contained a twist:

Should Paramount, backed by tech billionaire Larry Ellison, pull off the purchase, Warner Bros. Discovery Chief Executive David Zaslav could stay on to help lead the combined enterprise.

“They're sweetening the pot,” Paul Hardart, a professor at New York University's Stern School of Business, said of the Ellison family. “It just shows all the little arrows in their quiver they're using to try to push this deal.”

David Ellison's unexpected olive branch to Zaslav was contained in an October letter to Warner Bros. Dis-



JORDAN STRAUSS Invision
DAVID ZASLAV vowed not to be “outworked.”

covery's board that offered \$58 billion in cash and stock for the entire company. The move underscores the family's determination to win the entertainment company that includes HBO, CNN and Warner Bros. film and television studios — and an obstacle in their path.

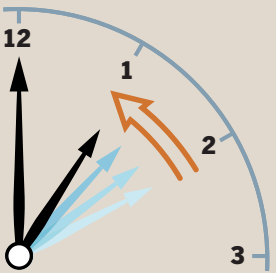
After hustling for decades to get to the big stage, Zaslav, 65, isn't ready to relinquish the reins. He's eager to prove critics wrong and complete a turnaround after

[See Warner, A10]

Video casts doubt on U.S. claims

The feds say a TikTok star had escaped ICE. But a clip appears to show six agents letting him go.

Business **A15**
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Timely reminder
Daylight saving time ended Sunday at 2 a.m.



Illustration by DANIEL JURMAN For The Times

In the spirit of giving
Need inspiration with the holiday season quickly approaching? Our annual Gift Guide has you covered. See **SECTION T** and latimes.com/giftguide.

Weather

Mostly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 75/56. **B8**



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